The New Church: A New Beginning

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A previous talk was on the subject of the relationship which exists between Emanuel Swedenborg and the Church which is formed of believers in the doctrines contained in his theological Writings, the Church of the New Jerusalem, or the New Church. Mis-called the 'Swedenborgian' Church, as it sometimes is, the New Church had its beginnings in London in 1783, eleven years after Swedenborg's death, when a small group of receivers of those doctrines met together both to read and talk about them. And from there, it spread to many parts of the world. Swedenborg himself never sought to form a Church or even to gather together readers and receivers of the doctrines revealed through him. His special mission was to serve as the instrument through whom those doctrines could be given and, whilst he took an interest in their reception, distributed them where possible and defended them when they came under attack, it was left to others to found a Church where they would be taught and witnessed to.

However this is not to say that Swedenborg did not anticipate the establishment of a New Church, for in his Writings this is constantly spoken of. Indeed, he wrote of a new beginning for the Church; of the dawning of a new Christian era and of the opportunity people would henceforth have of knowing and understanding the Lord Jesus Christ and of entering into a truly meaningful relationship with Him. Obscured by a multiplication of false teachings as essential Christianity had become by the time of the 18th century, these were exposed and swept aside, and the foundation laid in the Revelation given through him, for a new spiritual age.

It is sometimes complained of the New Church that it is 'just another sect', as if there aren't enough already. But in reality, and it is important to note this, the New Church is far more than just an organisation. It is Christianity redefined and newly begun. To speak of it as just a sect suggests no more than yet another splinter group within the framework of the old understanding and approach to things. But what in fact is involved is a whole new step forward, just as the earlier establishment of the Christian Church was a step forward from the ancient Jewish Church which had gone before it. In point of fact, a new age is involved.

And here is what in particular, I would like to take up with you in this talk; this teaching, this concept, that we are living in a new Christian age, even though as yet only at the very beginning of it. If we look at the world around us, we find much that seems to suggest anything but a new Christian age, even the possibility of it. If we stop to catalogue them in any detail, we can get a very gloomy picture of things and we easily come to a pessimistic outlook, which many have. Things happen which shock and distress us, and tensions and rivalries continue to bedevil our relationships, whether in terms of the nations of the world, or as individuals, one with another. And what is very obvious, whilst at one time the old values and standards were accepted scarcely without question, certainly without them being openly questioned, now this is no longer so. And yet we talk of a new spiritual age; of Christianity and its new beginning. We do well to stop for a moment and to think about the immediately assessable effects on the world of the Lord's first Coming, not only in terms of the things He taught but also in terms of the re-organisation of the spiritual world which He carried out at that time. In effect there was very little outwardly observable change, for all that, by His Coming the Lord had inaugurated a new spiritual age for mankind. Government continued to be conducted in the same way as it had been before; the standards of morality continued as they had done previously. And while Christians spoke of a new age for mankind, most people mocked and derided them. It took centuries before the new Christian order began to have a noticeable impact on human affairs. People had themselves to come to see the value and worth of Christian teaching, and it took a very long time before even a sizeable number did so.

And so it is also with this new Christian era. The Lord has, through Swedenborg, opened and explained the inner wisdom and spiritual meaning within His Word and given teachings which are the heart of a new Christian age and are its inspiration. But their impact is only slowly felt and readiness to accept them is itself a gradual thing. Though in that Revelation given through Swedenborg, the Lord has made His second Coming, yet in these early stages, and as with His first Coming, there is little observable indication that this is so.

But then the Lord does not impose an understanding of truth upon people. People must come to an understanding of truth themselves. And the very things we earlier spoke about - the questioning of old values

and the increasing insistence of one's right to think things out for oneself - are hopeful signs in this regard for the future. That a process of re-appraisal and re-assessment is going on few people seriously doubt. In the freer and more tolerant atmosphere in which we now live, evils are coming to the surface and are being acknowledged and talked about as they would never have been before. And this is being permitted, because it is the Lord's way of so leading people, ultimately, to see their need for something more worthwhile and more orderly, and of preparing them to receive the teaching given in His new Revelation.

It saddens us to look around the world and to see and read about the sorts of things that are taking place. There have been in the past and there takes place today crimes and atrocities which scarcely bear thinking about.

Long-established values are being challenged, and alternative forms of relationship—different from those once regarded as orderly—are being presented as legitimate for those who choose to enter them. But then evils must be permitted to come to the surface if there is to be any real chance of them being rejected. It is better this way than that they lie hidden away, only to build up within. And this is what is happening today. Evils and disorders are permitted to surface in order that humanity, wearied and saturated by their effects, may finally become ready to turn away from them. In a state of moral and spiritual upheaval as our civilization is, yet it is part of that process after which the new Christian age can properly come in.

Swedenborg wrote: ‘Before being reduced to order, it is very common for everything to fall into confusion or seeming chaos. This allows things that cling together poorly to separate, and when they have separated, the Lord arranges them in their place.

Nature offers parallels, since in it too each and every thing first falls into some degree of disorder before being put in order. If the skies did not storm, causing unlike elements to scatter, the air would never clear; destructive forces would amass and wreak havoc. It is the same with a person who is regenerating.’ (Arcana Caelestia 842) And so it is also with regard to mankind as a whole.

One of the most puzzling books in the Bible and difficult to understand, is the Book of Revelation which, of course, comes at the end. In it, John the Apostle, who was in exile on the isle of Patmos at the time, writes of strange visions and things he saw while 'in the spirit'. Clearly symbolic as these visions are, many unsuccessful attempts have been made to explain what they mean, it not being realised that the Book treats not of worldly events but of spiritual events; the end of the old Christianity and the coming of the new. After all the upheavals described in the earlier chapters in the Book, and prophetic as his words were meant to be, John writes, Chapter 21,"And I saw a new heaven and a new earth: for the first heaven and the first earth were passed away." And there we have it. An end and a new beginning. It was foreseen from the outset that the Christian Church would, as it did, lose its sense of purposes and direction and that a new start would have to be made; a new Christian Church would have to be raised up in its stead. And that is what these words of John describe.

Go back to them yourself and if you have never read them do so now. If you have read them, then read them again. *The Apocalypse*, or *Book of Revelation* we read:

> “The book of Revelation from beginning to end it has as its subject the last state of the church in heaven and on earth, and the Last Judgment, and after that the New Church, which is the New Jerusalem.” (*The Apocalypse Revealed* para.2)
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> "And I heard a great voice out of heaven, saying, Behold, the tabernacle of God is with men, and He will dwell with them, and they shall be His people, and God Himself shall be with them, and be their God. And God shall wipe away all tears from their eyes; and there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain: for the former things are passed away." (*Revelation* Chapter 21: verses 3 and 4)